

Working Hand in Hand

Mumbai Regional Congress Committee chief Kripashankar Singh shares his formula for victory and his reactions to accusations from detractors

Q The Congress & NCP won all the 6 Lok Sabha seats and 20 (17 + 3) Assembly seats in Mumbai, what do you want to say about this?

A I am just doing my job. This 'vote of confidence' is the trust of people of Mumbai in the Congress Party and its President Sonia Gandhi. I am just a soldier of the party, organising and implementing what needs to be done. I must salute the vision of our youth leader Rahul Gandhi. Today people from all over India are looking at Rahulji as the future of the country. In Mumbai, guided by Congress Party President Soniaji and the progressive policies of Prime Minister Dr. Manmohan Singh, we were able to gain the confidence of the people. During the PM's visit to Mumbai, he had declared that there would be no problem of funds for Mumbai's infrastructure projects and that Mumbai's development would be the priority of the Congress government.

Q Recently you have been attacked for being close to a tainted political leader. What are the real facts?

A The Congress party had given me some organisational work and my role is restricted to that only. I am not connected to any of these rumours or controversies. Where the people of Mumbai are concerned, I want to tell them that when it comes to the trust, the faith that they have entrusted in me, I will never let them down or do anything that would hurt them. In my 30-year political career, I have done no such thing that would hurt the common man.



Q In spite of a record performance, you have not found a place in the Maharashtra cabinet, are you upset about this?

A I am just a dedicated soldier of the Congress Party. The work assigned to me by the Congress party is still in the process of being implemented. The successful completion of assigned responsibilities is all that matters to me at present. I am not hankering after a cabinet post or for that matter any post.

Q Your opponent has filed an election petition against you, what do you wish to say?

A Winning elections is not just about personalities. The real factor that makes a great deal of difference to voters is the issues that a candidate stands for. A political leader should enjoy confidence of the people. The candidate's loyalty to the party should be undivided. People's expectations must be met. If anything is committed in the party manifesto, it should be fulfilled. People should have the confidence that the Congress party is doing something for them. Presently I will only say that my lawyers will deal with it as and when it is served upon me.

Q What are Mumbai's three major problems that you would want the state government to solve on priority?

A Firstly, tackling the slum problem is one of the biggest challenges that the state government has to resolve. From providing alternate accommodation to ensuring that encroachments do not recur, it requires a major effort from all concerned. Secondly, infrastructure is another issue that needs to be taken up on a war footing. People living in the slum have a right to lead a healthy life in a clean environment. Government will have to act on this. Wider and better roads, completion of ongoing projects like the comprehensive Sea Link from Bandra-Nariman Point, the Trans Harbour Link, these are all essential for the city's growth and progress. Thirdly, Ensuring safe and sufficient drinking water as well as improving the healthcare system including the municipal hospital are other priority areas where we will keep up the pressure. I will try to push these projects.